

You Don't Have to Be Perfect

追求完美让你焦虑？放下执念，重拾好奇心。拥抱不完美，解锁轻松快乐的人生！

Hard and fast thinkers want perfection, and defeat and failure are not in their vocabulary. For them, everything must be just so. However, no one is perfect. Thinking that we can be perfect is the path to definite failure. My parents were exacting about certain things in life, but not all. For example, my father handled his brush, ink, and rice paper meticulously during his calligraphy sessions. My mother was exacting in the kitchen. The rice had to be washed three times, and the vegetables scrubbed just as much. This type of perfection, fortunately, did not rule other areas of their lives. My parents were surprisingly hands-off about many things. Namely, they never once pestered me about bringing home straight A's, not that grades weren't important. Frankly, I was studious just enough. Perhaps my parents knew that demanding a straight A report card was plain old crazy-making for them and me. They never even used the word perfection.

Parents who expect a certain level of perfection use their children as vehicles for their own fulfillment and end up raising offspring who become overly focused on themselves. They think failure will ruin their lives. While they are careful about not making mistakes, they are missing out on valuable lessons. Such self-focus isn't a great backdrop for development. The perfectionist is close-minded in her thinking and behavior, and she is constantly concerned that she may lose her parents' validation, affection, and love.

A review of multiple studies from the United Kingdom found a rise in perfectionism in recent years. The cause of the increase may have resulted from various factors, including social comparison via social media and the rise of individualism. Not only has the demand for perfection by others steadily increased, but the demands we make on ourselves have increased as well. The results of such meta-analyses are normally strong and reliable because they consolidate data from previous peer-reviewed studies. Their primary lies in the robust analysis of multiple subjects.

According to research published in the *Journal of Cognitive Psychotherapy*, people who look for things to go wrong in life leave a door open to depression, a hallmark of perfectionist thinking. Psychologists view such a thought process as a cause of anxiety and other mood disorders. It is a frame of mind that also stokes other mental illnesses, including substance abuse and eating disorders. The link between perfectionism and eating disorders is real, and while there is a chicken and egg problem in deciphering whether perfectionism feeds the disorders or vice versa, the connection is clear. Among tweens and teenage girls, for example, perfectionism can be tied to the desire for a thin waistline and an amazing boyfriend.

Peter Gray, a psychologist and research professor at Boston College, suggests that there is little freedom in modern-day education and no autonomy to learn or to be curious. While children are innately curious, we do a good job of stamping it out. Genuine curiosity is a trait that is accepting of life. In effect, we open our eyes to find wonder and novelty in the world. It is the opposite of indifference and hard and fast beliefs.

Nowadays, we prepare children for standardized testing through rote memory, competition, and subject-focused learning. It is an

environment that can deaden children, ensuring they do not learn to be curious and open. Instead, Gray wants to see children utilize their critical thinking, deep understanding, collaborative nature, and inquisitive engagement.

Curiosity is a big part of positive psychology. When we want to learn new things, we are engaged with life, which fuels fulfillment and well-being. When we are curious, the worry of failure and perfection falls away. Curious people tend to be happier and less neurotic, while the unengaged and disinterested tend to be negative and depressed.

Children innately have loads of wonder, and this drives their motivation to figure out how the world works. We can reclaim this intuitive trait by opening our eyes, paying attention to what we see, and wondering out loud. Asking an open-ended question about what we are looking at is a good start. For some, this may take being uncomfortable. It requires a willingness to be wrong and saying, "I don't know." Doing so can feel unpleasant initially, but it serves as a vital safeguard against spiraling into endless negativity.